

2026.7.2

Transforming the cradle of the Confederacy

Tourists are flocking to monuments on America's racial history

ACROSS AMERICA more than 4,400 black people were lynched between 1877 and 1950. Some were killed for flirting with white women, others for talking back to bosses or trying to vote. In downtown Montgomery, Alabama, each of their names is carved into a rusted steel column marking the county where they lived and died. As visitors walk through the six-acre memorial the columns seem to rise. By the end they resemble a sea of dark bodies hanging heavily overhead.

Montgomery, Alabama's capital, once had more slave-trading depots than churches. More recently, it has become home to memorials that

改造邦联的摇篮

游客们正涌向展现美国种族历史的纪念地

在整个美国,1877年至1950年间有4400多名黑人被动用私刑处死。有些人因与白人女性调情而遇害,另一些人则因顶撞老板或试图投票而丧命。在阿拉巴马州蒙哥马利市中心,他们每个人的名字都被刻在了一根根锈蚀的钢柱上,以此标记他们生前生活和死去的县。当游客穿过这片占地六英亩的纪念地时,这些钢柱似乎在不断升高。走到尽头时,它们宛如一片沉重地悬挂在头顶的深色躯体之海。

作为阿拉巴马州的首府,蒙哥马利曾经拥有的奴隶贸易据点比教堂还要多。而近年来,这里成为了纪念这段历史的纪念地聚集区。就

commemorate this history. As Donald Trump sets out to build grand new structures in Washington, DC, Montgomery’s monuments offer another model of urban reinvention. About a decade after the project was conceived, Montgomery’s downtown is transformed and tourism is booming.

The project has been led by Bryan Stevenson, the founder of the Equal Justice Initiative (EJI), a non-profit law firm that defends death-row inmates. Mr Stevenson had observed how Berlin, Johannesburg and Kigali confronted their bleakest chapters. When he first moved to Montgomery, it didn’t have a single marker that mentioned “slavery”, yet had 59 monuments to the Confederacy and three high schools named for its war generals and soldiers. This seemed odd.

Montgomery had been home to the first White House of the Confederacy. It also is the city where, in 1955, Rosa Parks refused to relinquish her seat to a white passenger, sparking wide boycotts; where

在特朗普着手在华盛顿特区建造宏伟的新建筑之际，蒙哥马利的纪念碑提供了另一种城市重塑的模式。该项目在构思大约十年后，蒙哥马利的市中心已然发生蜕变，旅游业正蓬勃发展。

该项目一直由布莱恩·史蒂文森领导，他是平等司法倡议（EJI）的创始人，这是一家为死刑犯辩护的非营利性律师事务所。史蒂文森先生曾观察过柏林、约翰内斯堡和基加利是如何直面各自最黑暗历史篇章的。当他最初搬到蒙哥马利时，这里没有一个地方提及“奴隶制”，却拥有 59 座纪念美利坚邦联的纪念碑，还有三所全日制高中以邦联的战将军队和士兵命名。这显得颇为古怪。

蒙哥马利曾是邦联第一个白宫的所在地。这也是在 1955 年，罗莎·帕克斯拒绝向白人乘客让座，从而引发广泛抵制运动的城市；是种族隔离主义者炸毁马丁·路德·金住宅的城市；是一群暴徒在公交总

segregationists bombed Martin Luther King junior's home; where a mob beat activists at a bus depot; where George Wallace, Alabama's governor, declared "segregation forever" in 1963; and where, two years later, the long march from Selma concluded with King calling for "a society that can live with its conscience" from the steps of the state Capitol. So, Mr Stevenson set out to develop sites to tell the story of American slavery, racial violence and civil rights.

With private financing, he opened the memorial and a museum in 2018, then a few years later, a sculpture park and, this spring, a town square. In town halls, Mr Stevenson recalls, some locals used to be sceptical. That changed when they saw tourists, and cash, roll in.

Each month 50,000 people visit the "legacy sites", some coming from as far as Europe and Asia. Demand is such that, in the past year, EJI has partnered with for-profit groups to open a five-star hotel, two restaurants and a coffee shop, ventures that might inspire reluctant

站殴打活动家的地方；是阿拉巴马州州长乔治·华莱士在 1963 年宣称“现在隔离，永远隔离”的地方；也是两年后，从塞尔玛开始的长途进军宣告结束的地方，当时金在州议会大厦的阶梯上呼吁建立“一个能够凭良心生活的社会”。因此，史蒂文森先生着手开发这些场所，以讲述美国奴隶制、种族暴力和民权的故事。

在私人资金的资助下，他于 2018 年开放了纪念地和一家博物馆，几年后又开放了一座雕塑公园，并于今年春天开放了一个城镇广场。史蒂文森先生回忆说，在市政厅会议上，一些当地人过去常持怀疑态度。但当他们看到游客以及现金滚滚而来时，态度便发生了转变。

每个月有 5 万人参观这些“遗产地”，有些游客甚至远道来自欧洲和亚洲。需求是如此之大，以至于在过去一年中，EJI 与营利性机构合作，开设了一家五星级酒店、两家餐厅和一家咖啡馆，这些商业尝试甚至可能引起某位由纽约开发商转行进军政坛的政治家的

admiration from a certain New York developer turned politician. Profits go back into funding the museums and memorials. The hotel, named Elevation, has some unusual features: the architects included a library and “reflection garden” and reduced the number of rooms to make communal areas for visitors to talk to each other.

High-end tourism to grapple with racism is either a triumph or caricature of American capitalism, depending on your view. For Montgomery, though, the legacy sites have clearly been a boon. “It’s been a game changer,” says Ron Simmons of the Montgomery Regional Chamber of Commerce. Tourists stay in town twice as long as they did a decade ago. Last year 1.4m visitors spent \$1.4bn, roughly four times the city’s annual budget.

Combined with big new investments from Amazon, Meta and manufacturers, surging tourism means that Montgomery’s economy is, according to its mayor, Steven Reed, in its best financial position in 30

勉强赞赏。利润会重新用于资助博物馆和纪念地。这家名为 Elevation 的酒店有一些不寻常的特色：建筑师在里面加入了一个图书馆和一座“沉思花园”，并减少了客房数量，以腾出公共区域供游客彼此交流。

利用高端旅游业来直面种族主义，这究竟是美国资本主义的胜利还是讽刺，取决于你的视角。不过对蒙哥马利而言，这些遗产地显然带来了一笔福祉。蒙哥马利区域商会的罗恩·西蒙斯表示：“这彻底改变了局面。”游客在城里逗留的时间比十年前延长了一倍。去年，140 万名游客消费了 14 亿美元，大约是该市年度预算的四倍。

根据该市市长史蒂文·里德的说法，激增的旅游业再加上来自亚马逊、Meta 以及制造商的大笔新投资，意味着蒙哥马利的经济正处于 30 年来的最佳财政状况。该市正利用新的财政收入来拆除废弃

years. The city is using new revenue to raze abandoned buildings, give grants to small businesses, hire more police and invest in financial-literacy programmes. In May the city launched a “midnight basketball” league, to occupy young people when they might otherwise get into trouble.

Last year, in an executive order titled “Restoring Truth and Sanity to American History”, Mr Trump instructed federally funded museums and parks to remove exhibits that “degrade shared American values” or “divide Americans based on race”. The president has taken particular exception to the Smithsonian Institution for emphasising “how bad Slavery was”.

Mr Stevenson’s projects are immune from this pressure—because he is in the business of litigating against the government, he has never taken a penny of state or federal funding. Mr Reed notes that “pointing out truths doesn’t mean pointing your finger.” Asked what Montgomery

建筑、向小企业提供资助、雇用更多警察并投资于提高金融素养的项目。今年 5 月，该市启动了一个“午夜篮球”联赛，以便让年轻人在可能滋生事端的时间段有事可做。

去年，在一份名为《恢复美国历史的真相与理智》的行政命令中，特朗普先生指示由联邦资助的博物馆和公园移除那些“贬低共同的美国价值观”或“基于种族分裂美国人”的展品。总统对史密森尼学会尤其不满，指责其过分强调“奴隶制有多么糟糕”。

史蒂文森先生的项目则免受这种压力——因为他的本职工作是起诉政府，他从未拿过州或联邦政府的一分钱资助。里德先生指出：“指出真相并不意味着用手指着别人指责。”当被问及蒙哥马利现在向游客展现了什么时，他说，是“一种持久的爱国主义”。

now represents to its visitors, he says, “an enduring patriotism”.

America is mighty—but becoming less dominant

Ahead of its 250th birthday, an empirical look shows the world's leading country no longer stands so far apart

美国虽强大——但主导地位正在下降

在其 250 岁生日即将来临之际，一项实证研究显示，这个世界领先的国家已不再那么一枝独秀

Discussions of American power are prone to hyperbole. In his first inauguration speech, in 2017, Donald Trump lamented “American carnage”. In his second, in 2025, he declared that “America will reclaim its rightful place as the greatest, most powerful, most respected nation on earth.” Americans themselves are gloomy about their country’s role on the global stage. Six in ten now think that, by 2050, their country will be “less important in the world” than today. But has America’s global power actually been in decline? And what is the nature of American strength? These are questions on which many politicians offer opinions, which in turn can help win elections, guide policy and reshape the world.

关于美国权力的讨论往往容易流于夸张。在其 2017 年的首次就职演说中，特朗普哀叹“美国浩劫”。而在他 2025 年的第二次就职演说中，他宣称“美国将夺回其作为地球上最伟大、最强大、最受尊敬国家的应有地位。”美国人自己对本国在全球舞台上的角色也感到悲观。如今，十分之六的人认为，到 2050 年，他们的国家在世界上的“重要性将不如今天”。但美国的全球权力实际上真的在衰落吗？美国实力的本质又是什么？对于这些问题，许多政治家都发表了意见，而这些意见反过来又能帮助赢得选举、引导政策并重塑世界。

So, to mark America’s 250th anniversary, The Economist set out to

因此，为了纪念美国建国 250 周年，《经济雪人》着手从主观转向

move from the subjective to the quantifiable, with an empirical examination of America's global might. Economically, militarily and technologically, the country is richer, stronger and cleverer than ever. However its relative position is not what it was. We find that, by the numbers, its dominance appears to be eroding—with decisions being made now that may bulk up some forms of power and starve others.

The nation's rocketing trajectory can be tracked most easily through the rise of its economy. In 1820, the year in which comparable economic figures began, America was a small country of roughly 10m people, including European settlers, slaves and native Americans. Its land area was less than half its current size; its economy about one-tenth that of the British Empire, itself overshadowed by Qing-dynasty China, which controlled roughly a quarter of the world's economic output.

Fuelled by war, colonisation and the industrial revolution, the British

可量化，对美国的全球威力进行了一次实证检验。在经济、军事和技术上，这个国家比以往任何时候都更富有、更强大、更聪明。然而，它的相对地位已今非昔比。我们发现，从数据来看，它的主导地位似乎正在受到侵蚀——而现在做出的决定可能会壮大某些形式的权力，同时使其他形式的权力陷入枯竭。

这个国家火箭般的上升轨迹最容易通过其经济的崛起来追踪。在 1820 年（可比经济数据开始统计的那一年），美国还是一个只有大约 1000 万人口的小国，其中包括欧洲定居者、奴隶和美洲原住民。它的土地面积还不到现在的一半；其经济规模大约是实为大英帝国的十分之一，而大英帝国本身当时也逊色于清朝统治下的中国，后者控制着全球约四分之一的经济产出。

在战争、殖民化和工业革命的推动下，大英帝国在 1840 年左右（两

Empire overtook China as the world's largest economy around 1840, when the first opium war between the countries was under way. America was, however, catching up fast.

The invention of the cotton gin in 1793 and brutal deployment of slave labour meant that the country produced most of the world's cotton by the 1850s. America expanded, often violently, westward, gaining natural resources that would be the envy of the world.

Sprawling forests supplied timber for rapid construction. Well-positioned ports and the sweeping Mississippi river provided routes for export. Coal mines in Pennsylvania, Appalachia and the Midwest powered railroads and factories; the Great Lakes' rich deposits of iron ore fed steel mills. Civil war ravaged the country but did not destroy it, ending slavery in 1865.

Industrialising rapidly, America overtook Great Britain as a guzzler of

国爆发第一次鸦片战争时）超越中国，成为全球最大的经济体。然而，美国正在快速赶超。

1793 年轧棉机的发明和对奴隶劳动力的残酷榨取，意味着到 1850 年代，这个国家生产了世界上大部分的棉花。美国向西扩张（通常带有暴力色彩），获得了令世界羡慕的自然资源。

蔓延的森林为快速建设提供了木材。地理位置优越的港口和纵横交错的密西西比河提供了出口路线。宾夕法尼亚州、阿巴拉契亚地区和中西部的煤矿为铁路和工厂提供了动力；五大湖区丰富的铁矿石储量滋养了钢铁厂。内战蹂躏了这个国家，但并未将其摧毁，并于 1865 年结束了奴隶制。

随着工业化的迅速推进，美国在 1891 年超越大不列颠，成为能源

energy in 1891. We calculate that in 1899—after the Spanish-American war and the Treaty of Paris, which gave it control of Puerto Rico, Guam and the Philippines—it controlled more fertile land than any country bar the Russian empire. A few years later, in 1903, America had the world's largest economy.

America's dominance grew as Europe was drained by war. In 1945, as much of the world lay in smouldering ruins, America's economy peaked in relative terms. Alone among the great powers, its territory was largely untouched by the war. A country with 6% of the world's population controlled roughly a third of its economic output.

America's economy then took off, driven by industrial strength, ravenous consumer demand and state investment—in national laboratories, for instance, and highways. It helped that oil, having been discovered in Pennsylvania in the mid-19th century, began gushing from Texas wells in the 20th.

消耗大国。我们计算出，在 1899 年——即美西战争和《巴黎条约》（该条约使美国获得了对波多黎各、关岛和菲律宾的控制权）之后——美国控制的肥沃土地除了俄罗斯帝国之外比任何国家都多。几年后的 1903 年，美国拥有了全球最大的经济体。

随着欧洲因战争而耗尽元气，美国的主导地位进一步增强。1945 年，当世界上大部分地区还处于冒烟的废墟中时，美国的经济在相对意义上达到了顶峰。在各大国中，只有其本土基本上未受到战争的波及。一个占世界人口 6% 的国家控制了全球大约三分之一的经济产出。

随后，在工业实力、饥渴的消费需求以及国家投资（例如在国家实验室和公路上的投资）的驱动下，美国经济一飞冲天。在 20 世纪，19 世纪中叶在宾夕法尼亚州发现的石油开始从德克萨斯的油井中喷涌而出，这对此也大有裨益。

Add immigration, a reliable rule of law, ample capital and animal spirits, and America's economy raced ahead, growing more in absolute terms between 1945 and 1999 than any other country. Its researchers developed the building blocks of modern life, including the transistor, the computer chip, the personal computer and the internet.

Today America's economy is smaller than China's, adjusted for local prices. But it is still by far the world's largest at 2025 exchange rates, with a gross domestic product (GDP) of \$32.4trn, 55% bigger than China's, at number two. It is leading the development of generative artificial intelligence and has become the world's biggest producer of crude oil and natural gas. Unlike many other countries—including China, Russia and much of East Asia and Europe—it has a population that is growing. The dollar accounts for the highest share of global trade invoices and about half of international payments. Its entrepreneurs are the world's most successful: in the past 40 years,

再加上移民、可靠的法治、充裕的资本和企业家精神，美国经济奋勇向前，在 1945 年至 1999 年之间的绝对增长额超过了其他任何国家。它的研究人员开发出了现代生活的基石，包括晶体管、电脑芯片、个人电脑和互联网。

如今，经过本地价格调整后，美国的经济规模小于中国。但在 2025 年的汇率下，它仍是迄今为止全球最大的经济体，国内生产总值（GDP）达 32.4 万亿美元，比排名第二的中国高出 55%。它正引领着生成式人工智能的发展，并已成为全球最大的原油和天然气生产国。与包括中国、俄罗斯以及东亚和欧洲大部分地区在内的许多其他国家不同，美国的人口正在增长。美元在全球贸易结算中占最高份额，并占国际支付的一半左右。它的创业者是世界上最成功的：在过去 40 年里，全球十家市值最高的公司中有五家诞生于美国，其中四家至少部分由移民创立。

America has produced five of the world's ten most valuable firms, four of them founded at least in part by immigrants.

With the country at the centre of the world's economy, America has used its might to elevate the world's poor and punish its enemies. It has given some \$2trn, in 2026 dollars, in official development assistance (ODA) since 1960, according to tallies by the OECD, a club of mostly rich countries. The pervasive dollar lets America use economic sanctions to isolate individuals, companies and entire countries.

An examination of American military power produces a similar portrait of unmatched strength. America was at its mightiest, in relative terms, in 1945, not least because it was the only country with nuclear weapons. In the decades that followed, its role became more complex. America helped create the post-war order, then set about defending it—British and American troops sometimes met in doorways of remote outposts, as one left and the other moved in. By 1965, America had

由于该国处于世界经济的中心，美国利用其威力来提升世界穷人的地位并惩罚其敌人。根据由大多数富裕国家组成的俱乐部——经合组织（OECD）的统计，自 1960 年以来，美国已提供了约 2 万亿美元（以 2026 年美元计算）的官方发展援助（ODA）。无处不在的美元让美国能够利用经济制裁来孤立个人、公司和整个国家。

对美国军事力量的审视也描绘出了一幅同样无可匹敌的实力图景。在相对意义上，美国在 1945 年实力最强，这在很大程度上是因为它是当时唯一拥有核武器的国家。在随后的几十年里，它的角色变得更加复杂。美国协助创建了战后秩序，随后便着手捍卫它——英国和美国的军队有时会在遥远哨所的门口相遇，一方撤离，另一方进驻。到 1965 年，美国在海外驻扎了超过 60 万名士兵，遍布 108 个国家。

over 600,000 soldiers stationed abroad, spread across 108 countries.

In the years since, it has spent much more than other countries on its armed forces. The might and animosity of the Warsaw Pact nations, staring down America’s soldiers across the Fulda Gap during the cold war, provided one reason. America’s position within NATO supplied another. In grand alliances, game theory suggests, the largest power will spend disproportionately more, as it has more to lose.

在自那以后的岁月里，它在军队上的开支远远超过其他国家。冷战期间，华约国家在富尔达缺口与美国士兵对峙的强大实力和敌意，提供了一个原因。美国在北约内部的地位提供了另一个原因。博弈论表明，在大国联盟中，最大的强国会付出极不成比例的更多开支，因为它的损失也最大。

Even comparisons of military spending may understate America’s hard power. No country has more advanced military technology or, arguably, is more experienced deploying it at scale (in some areas, generals in Ukraine now have an edge, showing the expertise that springs from desperation). America’s outlay over the decades has yielded kit that lasts: an aircraft-carrier, of which it has 11, may remain operational for half a century. China has just three, none of which has seen combat.

即使是军事开支的对比也可能低估了美国的硬实力。没有哪个国家拥有更先进的军事技术，或者说，在海量部署这些技术方面比美国更有经验（在某些领域，乌克兰的将军们现在占据优势，展示了源于绝境的专业能力）。美国几十年来的投入造就了经久耐用的装备：美国拥有 11 艘航母，其中一艘航母的服役时间可能长达半个世纪。中国只有三艘，且均未经历过实战。

Why, then, all the doomsaying on America's vertiginous decline? There is a difference between strength and dominance—a relative term that happens to be one of Mr Trump's favourites. America is stronger than ever, but on some economic measures it is less dominant. The dollar's share of global foreign-exchange reserves has been on a decades-long decline, to 57% last year. Most importantly, an American-led world order has buoyed other countries. That is either a feature or a flaw, depending on your vantage point.

Since 1945, the world economy has grown by a factor of 19, and average incomes have risen roughly five-fold. China's rise, particularly after joining the World Trade Organisation (WTO) in 2001, has infuriated Mr Trump. It became the world's largest economy at local prices about a decade ago. On two measures dear to Mr Trump—manufacturing output and the export of goods—America's total volume has risen on an absolute basis, but has lagged in relative terms. In 1945 America produced about half of the world's

那么，为什么还会有这么多关于美国急剧衰落的末日预言呢？实力与主导地位之间是有区别的——“主导地位”是一个相对的概念，碰巧也是特朗普先生最喜欢的词汇之一。美国比以往任何时候都更强大，但在某些经济指标上，它的主导地位正在下降。去年，美元在全球外汇储备中的份额已降至 57%，延续了长达数十年的下降趋势。最重要的是，一个由美国领导的世界秩序造就了其他国家。这究竟是一个特征还是一个缺陷，取决于你看问题的视角。

自 1945 年以来，世界经济增长了 19 倍，平均收入增长了大约五倍。中国的崛起，尤其是在 2001 年加入世界贸易组织（WTO）之后，令特朗普先生大为恼火。大约十年前，按本地价格计算，中国成为了全球最大的经济体。在特朗普先生看重的两项指标——制造业产出和商品出口——上，美国的总额在绝对基础上有所上升，但在相对意义上已经落后。1945 年，美国生产了全球约一半的制造品；到 2024 年，这一比例降至 15% 左右，而中国的制造业份额是其两倍多。尽管美国出口的服务是中国的两倍，但特朗普先生谴责的是相

manufactured goods; by 2024, it accounted for about 15%, with China’s share of manufacturing more than twice that. Never mind that America exports twice as many services as China; Mr Trump decries the relatively low export of goods.

There is also a perception, at least among some, that the post-war order has brought ordinary citizens a measly return on investment. It has become clear—in Iraq, Afghanistan and, more recently, Iran—that military capability alone does not guarantee military success. All those aircraft-carriers cannot prevent Iran from choking off the passage of oil through the Strait of Hormuz or stop China from limiting access to rare earths.

Nearly six in ten Americans surveyed in 2024 thought that America had lost more than it had gained from trade with other countries. “The wealth of our middle class,” Mr Trump declared in 2017, “has been ripped from their homes and then redistributed across the entire world”.

对较低的商品出口。

至少在某些人看来，还存在一种认知，即战后秩序给普通公民带来的投资回报微乎其微。在伊拉克、阿富汗以及最近的伊朗已经很清楚地表明，单凭军事能力并不能保证军事上的成功。所有那些航空母舰都无法阻止伊朗切断霍尔木兹海峡的石油通道，也无法阻止中国限制稀土的获取。

在 2024 年受访的美国人中，近六成认为美国在与其他国家的贸易中得不偿失。“我们中产阶级的财富，”特朗普先生在 2017 年宣称，“已从他们的家中被剥夺，然后重新分配到了整个世界”。大卫·奥托尔、大卫·多恩和高登·汉森的研究显示，所谓的“中国冲击”

The so-called “China shock” did have an impact, in the loss of up to 2.4m jobs from 1999 to 2011, according to research from David Autor, David Dorn and Gordon Hanson. However painful for those individuals, that did not rattle America’s broader job market. At the end of 2011 America saw regular churn of about 4m jobs each month.

The post-war order clearly promoted American prosperity. Since 1960, real incomes have increased more in America in absolute terms than in any other large country or region, rising more than five times as much as incomes in India and twice as much as incomes in China. Among countries with more than 20m citizens, America is by far the richest, nearly 20% higher than Australia at number two. Median family income has more than doubled in real terms since 1960. Inequality in America is real, and above the average in rich countries. That has much to do with rising returns to wealth and America’s tax structure.

确实产生了影响，在 1999 年至 2011 年期间导致了多达 240 万个职位的流失。尽管对这些个人来说是痛苦的，但这并没有撼动美国更广泛的就业市场。在 2011 年底，美国每月都有约 400 万个职位的常规更替。

战后秩序显然促进了美国的繁荣。自 1960 年以来，美国实际收入的绝对增长额超过了其他任何大国或地区，其增幅是印度收入增幅的五倍多，是中国收入增幅的两倍。在人口超过 2000 万的国家中，美国是迄今为止最富有的，比排名第二的澳大利亚高出近 20%。自 1960 年以来，家庭收入中位数在扣除通胀后增长了一倍多。美国的贫富差距是现实存在的，且高于富裕国家的平均水平。这在很大程度上与财富回报率的上升以及美国的税收结构有关。

Mr Trump and his acolytes are now keen to renew American strength, or at least to forge a new version of it. He has a distinctly 19th-century interest in new territory, and the resources that come with it. Last year military spending by America's allies, when adjusted for local prices, surpassed America's. The White House has proposed a \$1.5trn defence budget for the 2027 fiscal year, a 44% increase on 2026. After adjusting for factors such as higher wages for soldiers to make figures comparable across countries, America's military spending would still be twice that of any other country. However the president is explicit that American strength does not guarantee protection of allies. A NATO summit on July 7th and 8th will centre on Europe's need to take more responsibility for defending itself. AI may become an important new tool of leverage.

Mr Trump seems happy to let America's power atrophy in other areas where it was once strong. Last year USAID, the country's main development agency, was fed "into the woodchipper", in the words and

特朗普先生和他的追随者们现在热衷于重振美国的实力，或者至少是打造一个新版本的实力。他对新领土以及随之而来的资源有着明显的 19 世纪式的兴趣。去年，经本地价格调整后，美国盟友的军事开支超过了美国。白宫已为 2027 财年提出了 1.5 万亿美元的国防预算，比 2026 年增加了 44%。在调整了士兵工资提高等因素以使各国数据具有可比性之后，美国的军事开支仍将是其他任何国家的两倍。然而，总统明确表示，美国的实力并不保证对盟友的保护。7 月 7 日和 8 日举行的北约峰会将聚焦于欧洲需要承担更多自身防卫责任的议题。人工智能可能会成为一个重要的新杠杆工具。

特朗普先生似乎乐于看到美国在其他曾经强大的领域任由实力萎缩。去年，在该国主要开发机构美国国际开发署（USAID）“被喂进了木材粉碎机”，这是目前已是的亿万富豪的埃隆·马斯克的原话

at the direction of Elon Musk, now a trillionaire. Annual transfers were slashed to \$29bn, about half their former level. America now gives about as much aid as Germany, which has an economy one-fifth its size.

Mr Trump is similarly sanguine about the risks to America's pre-eminence in research and innovation. America has more of the world's top universities than any other country—35 out of the top 100—but this number is dropping. China's spending on research and development exceeded America's in 2024, OECD figures suggest. More than a third of top journal articles are now written by Chinese researchers, who published as many papers as their American, British, German and Japanese peers combined in 2025.

At the very pinnacle of science—Nobel prizes—America remains dominant. That is probably a lagging indicator. Over the past decade, the median recipient has been 72 years old. More than 7,800 research

并由其主导。每年的拨款被削减至 290 亿美元，大约是先前水平的一半。美国现在提供的援助金额大约与德国相当，而德国的经济规模仅为美国的五分之一。

特朗普先生对美国在研究和创新领域的领先地位所面临的风险同样感到乐观。在世界顶尖大学中，美国拥有的数量超过其他任何国家——在前 100 名中占了 35 所——但这个数字正在下降。经合组织的数据显示，2024 年中国在研发方面的支出超过了美国。现在，超过三分之一的顶级期刊论文由中国研究人员撰写，他们在 2025 年发表的论文数量与美国、英国、德国和日本同行的总和相当。

在科学的最顶端——诺贝尔奖——美国仍保持着主导地位。这可能是一个滞后指标。在过去十年中，获奖者的年龄中位数为 72 岁。据科学期刊《自然》(Nature) 估计，在特朗普第二任期的第一年里，

grants were frozen or terminated during the first year of Mr Trump’s second term, estimates Nature, a scientific journal, with some 25,000 scientists and staff leaving federal science agencies. The president seems happy to cede innovation in green technologies to America’s rivals.

Most dramatic, and in contrast to much of the country’s 250-year history, is the ascendant view that this nation of immigrants is harmed by them. America may have near-zero net migration in 2025 and 2026. Polling by Gallup suggests that America remains the top destination for migrants overall, but just 15% of adults who say they want to move permanently to another country now name America as their top choice, down from 24% in 2007-09. In polling by Nira Data of 46,667 people in 85 countries, respondents ranked America as the world’s fifth-most-disliked country, more abhorrent than even Russia or China.

This swing in sentiment may be temporary, linked to an unpopular

有超过 7800 项研究资助被冻结或终止，约有 25000 名科学家和工作人员离开了联邦科学机构。总统似乎乐于将绿色技术的创新让给美国的竞争对手。

最戏剧性的变化，且与该国 250 年历史中的大部分时间形成鲜明对比的是，一种占据主导地位的观点认为这个移民国家受到了移民的伤害。美国在 2025 年和 2026 年可能会出现近乎零的净移民。盖洛普（Gallup）的民意调查显示，美国整体上仍是移民的首选目的地，但目前表示想永久移居另一个国家的成年人中，只有 15% 的人将美国作为首选，低于 2007-09 年期间的 24%。在 Nira Data 对 85 个国家的 46667 人进行的民意调查中，受访者将美国列为全球第五大最令人反感的国家，其令人厌恶的程度甚至超过了俄罗斯或中国。

这种情绪的转变可能是暂时的，与一位不受欢迎的总统及其政策有

president and his policies. Among America's greatest strengths is its dynamism, and its ability to change course. For now those outside America's borders observe, with caution, a country that is still mighty—but in motion.

关。在美国最大的优势中，包括了它的活力以及改变路线的能力。目前，美国边境以外的人们正带着谨慎的态度观察着一个依然强大——但正处于变动之中的国家。

Show a liberal a Lime bike and he will show you his soul

给自由主义者看一辆 **Lime** 共享单车，

他就会向你展现他的灵魂

Are the e-bikes a paragon of liberalism or an abomination?

电动自行车究竟是自由主义的典范，还是一个毒瘤？

These days it can be hard to know what a liberal really believes. Thankfully a simple test throws light on their soul. It is similar to the one Hermann Rorschach designed in the 1920s. Though instead of putting the subject in front of an ambiguous inkblot and waiting for them to say something profound about their mother, wheel in a white and green Lime Gen4 electric bike, found stacked by the dozen on city streets around the world, let their eyes settle on it and gently ask: “What do you see?”

如今，人们很难搞懂一个自由主义者真正相信什么。幸好，一个简单的测试就能洞察他们的灵魂。这类似于赫尔曼·罗夏在 2000 年代 20 年代设计的测试。不过，这里不需要让受试者面对一张模糊的墨迹图，并等待他们对自己的母亲发表一番高深的见解，而是推过来一辆白绿相间的 **Lime Gen4** 电动自行车——这种车在各地的城市街道上成打地堆放着——让他们的目光落在上面，然后温和地问一句：“你看到了什么？”

“That is the paragon of liberal capitalism!” exclaims the first subject. What’s not to love? The Lime rider accelerates quickly and without effort. He feels good about his carbon footprint and better about being spared the collectivism of public transport. Each bike is an advert for

“那是自由资本主义的典范！”第一位受试者惊呼。这有什么让人不喜欢的呢？**Lime** 的骑行者加速迅猛且毫不费力。他对自己的碳足迹感到满意，而更让他高兴的是，自己得以免受公共交通集体主义的束缚。每辆自行车都是创造性毁灭的广告：如果连笨拙的自行

creative destruction: if even the humble bicycle can be improved by innovation, anything can. Since Lime bikes are “dockless”, which allows the rider to leave them pretty much anywhere, the bikes bestow on riders of only modest means the highest of modern luxuries: nonchalance in travel.

One liberal’s casual dismount is another’s brazen incivility. “That is the devil!” the second subject shouts. Electric bikes have made pavement indistinguishable from road. Accidents are common enough that “Lime leg” has entered the vernacular. In London even the most genteel public spaces are dominated by neon-green handle-bars. So many descended on Wimbledon this week that the council threatened to seize them. On a recent morning Old Burlington Street in Mayfair was blocked with a great number of Limes parked on the pavement and road. In the mêlée stood a few Voi bikes, a pinkish-coloured Swedish competitor, and the odd Forest, a less offensively green British one, which appeared to have lost their way. If the subject has even a mild reactionary inclination,

车都能通过创新得以改进，那么任何事物都可以。由于 Lime 自行车是“无桩”的，允许骑行者几乎可以将其停在任何地方，这些自行车便赋予了资产微薄的骑行者以现代最顶级的奢侈：出行时的无拘无束。

一个自由主义者的随性下车，在另一个自由主义者眼里就是厚颜无耻的粗俗。“那是魔鬼！”第二位受试者喊道。电动自行车已经让非机动车道与机动车道变得无法区分。事故频繁发生，以至于“Lime 腿”（Lime leg，指因骑该单车受伤）已经成了日常俗语。在伦敦，即使是最文雅的公共空间也被霓虹绿的车把所占据。本周有如此多的单车涌入温布尔登，以至于区议会威胁要予以没收。在最近的一个早晨，梅费尔区的旧伯灵顿街被大量停在人行道和车道上的 Lime 单车堵得水泄不通。在这场混战中，还停着几辆 Voi 单车（一家带点粉色的瑞典竞争对手）以及零星的 Forest 单车（一家绿色没那么刺眼的英国对手），它们看起来像是迷了路。如果受试者哪怕有一点点保守主义的倾向，这样的景象也会让其立刻爆发。

such a sight will cause it to erupt immediately.

The two positions are irreconcilable. Even the initial fence-sitter (“I wouldn’t mind them if they were prettier”) will soon leap onto one side or the other. Subjects of the first kind accuse the second of being stick-in-the-muds who are unprepared for the changes technology will soon bring. The second subject thinks the first would live in the squalor of downtown San Francisco so long as their food delivery arrives on time.

这两种立场是不可调和的。即使是最初持中立态度的人（“如果它们更好看一点，我倒不介意”）很快也会跳向其中一边。第一类受试者指责第二类人是墨守成规的老古董，对技术即将带来的变革毫无准备。第二位受试者则认为，只要外卖能准时送达，第一类人甚至愿意住在旧金山市中心那种肮脏混乱的环境里。

What are you looking at when you are looking at a Lime? For one, a relic of the tech bubble that popped when central banks raised interest rates in 2022. Lime eventually went public on July 1st, after years of waiting. Countless “micro-mobility” firms have gone bust. Ofo, a Chinese company that once dumped thousands of yellow bikes in the West, is long gone. Jump, Uber’s attempt at shared e-bikes, was folded into Lime in 2020. Bird, a one-time e-scooter unicorn, declared

当你看着一辆 Lime 时，你到底在看什么？首先，它是科技泡沫的遗物，该泡沫在 2022 年中央银行提高利率时破裂了。在经历了多年的等待后，Lime 终于在 7 月 1 日上市。无数的“微出行”公司已经破产。曾在中国向西方投放数万辆黄色自行车的 ofo 早已消失。优步（Uber）在共享电动自行车领域的尝试 Jump 已于 2020 年并入 Lime。曾经的电动滑板车独角兽 Bird 在 2023 年宣布破产（尽管此后又重新复苏）。定价竞争和资产折旧的某种结合总是罪魁祸首。

bankruptcy in 2023 (though it has since re-emerged). Some Lime 表示它已经解决了这些问题：它的自行车可以使用五年，且 combination of pricing competition and asset depreciation was always 现金流为正。尽管如此，该公司仍被迫上市以偿还其沉重的债务。 to blame. Lime says it has solved these problems: it gets five years of wear out of its bikes and is cashflow positive. Still, the firm was forced to list to pay off its heavy debts.

To fully comprehend the Lime bike examine its genealogy. Shared 要完全理解 Lime 自行车，需要研究它的谱系。共享自行车起源于 bikes have their origins on the political left: in the 1960s Dutch drifters 政治左翼：在 1960 年代，荷兰的流浪者将一些自行车刷成白色且 painted some white and left them unlocked. But Lime’s more recent 不落锁。但 Lime 更近的祖先是 2000 年代出现的政府资助计划。伦 ancestors are the state-sponsored schemes which emerged in the 2000s. 敦的“鲍里斯自行车”（Boris bikes，正式名称为“桑坦德单车”） London’s “Boris bikes”, formally called “Santander cycles”, are Lime’s 是 Lime 有桩单车的前辈（不出所料，它们的开光率近来一直在下 docked forebears (unsurprisingly, their usage has languished recently). 滑)。Lime 还有一些不守规矩且往往非法的表亲，即那些如今在城 Limes have unruly, and often illegal, cousins in the super-fast 市里横冲直撞、无人管束的超快改配置外卖电动车。此外，送货经 jerry-rigged food-delivery bikes which now career unchallenged around 济的核心巨头优步（Uber）是其主要资助者，优步是 Lime 的最大 cities. And a major benefactor in Uber, the kingpin of the delivery 投资者，通过在其应用程序中提供该单车，为 Lime 贡献了 14% economy, which is Lime’s largest investor and is responsible for 14% 收入。 of Lime’s revenue by offering the bikes through its app.

If the Lime bike has a philosophy it is convenience absolutism. That was a more explicit mantra in Silicon Valley in the 2010s than it is today, but is still the true idée fixe of the place. In some cities Amazon can now deliver groceries in less than half an hour (thanks to its own electric bike). Agentic commerce is billed as the forefront of artificial intelligence, but is also the cutting edge of food delivery. The dominance of convenience also means the decline of ownership. And so much of the anti-social nature of electric bikes is a result of that. “Why did you park your Lime bike there?” one might ask. “It’s not my bike.”

Ridin’ dirty

Often the politics of business is merely the politics of the road. Elon Musk, the world’s richest man, is also its richest car salesman. Europe’s industrial crisis is mostly a panic about Chinese electric vehicles. But the politics of bikes is particularly brutal: “Zo stops charging speeding e-bike riders,” yelled the front page of the New York Post in March,

如果说 Lime 自行车有一种哲学，那就是便利绝对主义。这是 2010 年代硅谷比今天更明确的信条，但至今仍是该地真正的核心执念。在一些城市，亚马逊现在可以在不到半小时内送达杂货（这得益于其自身的电动自行车）。具身智能商业被宣传为人工智能的前沿，但同时也是外卖配送的最前沿。便利性的主导地位也意味着所有权的下降。而电动自行车如此多的反社会特性正是这一结果造成的。“你为什么把你的 Lime 自行车停在那里？”有人可能会问。“这不是我的车。”

危险骑行

商业政治往往不过是道路政治。世界首富埃隆·马斯克同时也是世界上最富有的汽车销售商。欧洲的工业危机在很大程度上是对中国电动汽车的恐慌。但自行车的政治尤其残酷：“佐兰停止对超速电动自行车骑行者开罚单，”《纽约邮报》在 3 月份的头版大喊，指责该市市长佐兰·马姆达尼以牺牲行人利益为代价来保护外卖骑手。

accusing Zohran Mamdani, the city's mayor, of protecting delivery drivers at the expense of pedestrians. Partly that is because they are a ubiquitous nuisance. But also because complaining about the super-fast ones food-delivery drivers use is about the only way liberals can complain about the illegal immigrants who often ride them.

If the electric bike is the great symbol of state failure, crushing them is a way for the state to recover the appearance of strength. Police forces in America, Australia and Britain have all filmed themselves pulverising electric bikes and scooters deemed too fast or dangerous. Better the electric bike you know? Perhaps: a crackdown on illegal ones should benefit legal operators like Lime, goes one argument. Yet Lime, too, suffers the big consequences of small politics. In 2023 Paris voted to ban dockless e-scooters. States write their own safety rules. Licensing for bikes can be devolved to an absurd extent. London's 32 boroughs each have their own rules, causing stacks of one operator's bikes at their boundaries. A ridiculous sight. But an increasingly

部分原因是因为它们是无处不在的公害。但也因为，对外国卖员使用的超快电动车发牢骚，是自由主义者抱怨经常骑这些车的非法移民的唯一方式。

如果说电动自行车是国家治理失败的巨大象征，那么砸碎它们就是国家恢复强大形象的一种方式。美国、澳大利亚和英国的警察部队都曾拍摄过自己粉碎被认为速度过快或过于危险的电动自行车和滑板车的画面。两害相权取其轻？也许吧：有一种观点认为，对非法车辆的打击应该会让像 Lime 这样的合法运营商受益。然而，Lime 也承受着微观政治带来的巨大后果。2023 年，巴黎投票禁止了无桩电动滑板车。各州制定了自己的安全规则。自行车牌照的权限可以下放到荒谬的程度。伦敦的 32 个行政区各有各的规则，导致某家运营商的自行车在行政区边界上堆积如山。一幅滑稽的景象。但这也一幅日益让人习以为常的景象。

familiar one.

Can Bending Spoons thrive as a listed company?

A rare Italian software star uses the private-equity playbook

“I like the idea of leaving a mark,” said Luca Ferrari in an interview in April with *Corriere della Sera*, an Italian daily. He is the boss and co-founder of Bending Spoons, an Italian tech firm which acquires and turns around struggling apps such as Evernote, a note-taking service, and Eventbrite, a ticket-buy site. Mr Ferrari’s ambitions go beyond reviving software firms. He said that he wants to “shake-up” Italy’s lacklustre business culture by building a company of “international calibre” there.

A test of his firm’s calibre came on July 1st. That is when Bending Spoons, which derives its names from a scene in *The Matrix*, a sci-fi film, launched its initial public offering on the Nasdaq, an American tech-heavy stock exchange. This is a rare success for a country better known for *la dolce vita* than pioneering technology startups. Italy is

Bending Spoon 作为上市公司能蓬勃发展吗？

这家罕见的意大利软件明星企业借用了私募股权的玩法

“我喜欢留下印记的想法，”卢卡·费拉里在4月份接受意大利日报《晚邮报》(*Corriere della Sera*)采访时说道。他是 Bending Spoons 的老板兼联合创始人，这家意大利科技公司专门收购并扭转陷入困境的应用程序，如笔记服务 Evernote 和购票网站 Eventbrite。费拉里先生的雄心不止于复兴软件公司。他表示，他希望通过在意大利建立一家“国际水准”的公司，来“重塑”意大利缺乏活力的商业文化。

对该公司水准的一次考验在7月1日到来。就在这一天，Bending Spoons（其名称源自科幻电影《黑客帝国》中的一个场景）在美国科技股云集的纳斯达克交易所挂牌上市。对于一个以“甜蜜生活”（*la dolce vita*）而非开拓性技术初创公司闻名于世的国家来说，这是一个罕见的成功。意大利仅拥有两家独角兽企业（估值超过10

home to just two unicorns, private companies worth over \$1bn, compared with 37 for Germany and 33 for France. At the end of the first day of trading, Bending Spoons' market capitalisation surged to \$25.7bn, making it Italy's most valuable tech firm.

Like many Silicon Valley startups Bending Spoons' path to success started with failure. In 2010 Mr Ferrari, Matteo Danieli and Francesco Patarnello, recent engineering graduates, decided to develop Evertale, an app designed to create a log of users' activities. The digital diary was a dud, failing to attract users. But the trio were determined to try again. With their last \$40,000 to set up Bending Spoons along with Luca Querella, a fourth co-founder.

The failure helped the co-founders settle on a business model. Bending Spoons buys and fixes ailing digital companies which already have a decent product and a loyal customer base. It operates as a hybrid of a private-equity (pe) investor and a tech firm. Like a pe firm it slashes

亿美元的私营公司), 而德国有 37 家, 法国有 33 家。在上市首日交易结束时, Bending Spoons 的市值飙升至 257 亿美元, 成为意大利市值最高的科技公司。

与许多硅谷初创公司一样, Bending Spoons 的成功之路始于失败。2010 年, 刚从工程专业毕业的费拉里、马泰奥·达涅利和弗朗切斯科·帕塔内洛决定开发 Evertale, 这是一款旨在记录用户活动轨迹的应用程序。这款数字日记产品是个哑弹, 未能吸引到用户。但三人决心再试一次。他们用最后的 4 万美元, 与第四位联合创始人卢卡·奎雷拉一起创立了 Bending Spoons。

这次失败帮助联合创始人确定了商业模式。Bending Spoons 收购并整顿那些已经拥有不错产品和忠实用户群但陷入困境的数字公司。它的运作模式介于私募股权 (PE) 投资机构和科技公司之间。像私募股权公司一样, 它通过裁员来激进地削减成本, 在某些情况下甚

cost aggressively with job cuts, in some cases firing the entire staff and just holding on to the underlying technology. Another way it lowers costs by sharing some expenses with other companies in its portfolio, such as R&D. It also switches talented “Spooners” from one firm to another. It aims for an annualised return on capital of 25%, ambitious for a pe firm.

As the firm has grown, it has bought bigger names. The largest acquisition came earlier this year when it snapped up AOL, the American internet brand, for \$1.5bn. That follows its purchase of Eventbrite and Vimeo, a video-streaming platform, for \$500m and \$1,4bn respectively. It has become a tech conglomerate, encompassing 50 companies. Ten of them created 80% of the revenue (mainly through subscriptions) which grew from \$387m in 2023 to \$1.3bn last year.

Will Bending become a darling of the public markets? One worry that critics have is its borrowing, which it has used to fuel its acquisitions.

至会解雇全体员工，仅保留底层技术。另一种降低成本的方法是让其投资组合中的其他公司分摊部分费用，例如研发费用。它还会在不同公司之间调配有才华的 “Spooners”（公司员工）。它的目标是实现 25% 的年化资本回报率，这对于私募股权公司来说是非常宏大的目标。

随着公司的成长，它收购了名气更大的企业。最大的一笔收购发生在今年早些时候，当时它以 15 亿美元的价格将美国互联网品牌 AOL 收入囊中。在此之前，它分别以 5 亿美元和 14 亿美元的价格收购了 Eventbrite 和视频流媒体平台 Vimeo。它已经变成了一个包含 50 家公司的科技企业巨头。其中十家公司创造了 80% 的收入（主要通过订阅），其收入从 2023 年的 3.87 亿美元增长到去年的 13 亿美元。

Bending 会成为公开市场的宠儿吗？批评人士的一个担忧是它的借贷，该公司一直利用借贷来推动收购。其总债务达 44 亿美元，超

Total debt stands at \$4.4bn, or over six times its annualised operating profits (before depreciation and amortisation) from the first quarter of 2026. That compares to an average of two for Nasdaq-listed firms. Another concern is that many tech firms it buys are under threat from generative AI. That fear has contributed to the share price of Constellation Software, a similar tech conglomerate based in Toronto, falling by nearly half over the past year.

Even so, investors seem undeterred. Plenty of big names, such as Eric Schmidt, a former boss of Google, have backed the firm. “It’s not only the strategy that is impressive, but the quality of execution,” says Peter Singlehurst of Baillie Gifford, a Scottish asset manager and another investor. Mr Ferrari will have to convince a whole new set of investors of Bending Spoons’ magic. If not, his shake-up may end up looking more like a shake-out.

过其 2026 年第一季度年化营业利润（折旧及摊销前）的六倍。相比之下，纳斯达克上市公司的平均水平仅为两倍。另一个担忧是，它收购的许多科技公司正面临生成式人工智能的威胁。这种担忧已导致总部位于多伦多的类似科技巨头 Constellation Software 的股价在过去一年中下跌了近一半。

即便如此，投资者似乎并未被吓退。包括谷歌前老板埃里克·施密特在内的许多大名鼎鼎的人物都对该公司给予了支持。“令人印象深刻的不仅仅是战略，还有执行的质量，”苏格兰资产管理公司、同时也是该机构投资者的 Baillie Gifford 的彼得·辛格赫斯特表示。费拉里先生必须向全新的一批投资者证明 Bending Spoons 的魔力。否则，他的这场“重塑”(shake-up)最终可能看起来更像是一场“清洗”(shake-out)。